

GENESIS 2.5: opt-in OpenCL and CUDA acceleration for the GENESIS/PGENESIS compartmental neural simulator

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Abstract

GENESIS is a long-established compartmental neural simulator. PGENESIS extends it to MPI execution. We release GENESIS 2.5, an accelerator-enabled extension of GENESIS 2.4/PGENESIS 2.4, adding opt-in OpenCL and CUDA backends for the Hodgkin–Huxley channel-update path while keeping every existing CPU, MPI, model, and SLI-script workflow intact. A batched multi-step GPU kernel reaches $21.0 \pm 0.3\times$ (NVIDIA A40) and $21.9 \pm 0.3\times$ (NVIDIA A100) end-to-end wall-clock speedup at $N = 50\,000$ single-compartment neurons, matching the fp64 CPU to $\sim 10^{-7}$ V. Speedups are reported end-to-end throughout: both arms are timed identically, so construction, host–device transfers and per-step host work are inside every figure quoted here. This multiloop kernel is exact only for single-compartment (isopotential) neurons. We additionally implement and validate `hines_tree_eliminate`, a GPU tridiagonal (Hines) elimination kernel extending acceleration to real, axially-coupled multi-compartment dendritic trees. One GPU thread per neuron runs the identical elimination the CPU solver does. Measured on UMCS cluster NVIDIA A40/A100 GPUs (10 replicates), it reaches $37.3\times$ (A40) and $80.8\times$ (A100) step-phase speedup at $N = 50\,000$ neurons $\times$ 16 compartments, still rising with N ; end-to-end, where the unaccelerated construction phase bounds the achievable gain at these short run lengths, the same sweep gives $3.6\times$ and $3.9\times$. This kernel accelerates population-scale simulation, parallelizing across neurons rather than within a single tree. Against other simulators, GENESIS 2.5 runs the Vogels–Abbott COBAHH network (4000 cells, 5 s, matched connectivity, protocol and firing

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rate) $1.63 \pm 0.07\times$ faster than CoreNEURON and $2.04 \pm 0.09\times$ faster than NEURON 9.0.2 on the same node, all arms single-threaded CPU. Pushing this population toward the Blue Brain Project’s $\sim 31\,000$ -neuron microcircuit scale [9] surfaced a latent, GPU-independent $O(n^2)$ model-construction bottleneck. Fixing it restores linear scaling: a 1.7-million-compartment, $N = 100\,000$ population now builds in 51.5 ± 0.6 s, down from not finishing at all, a correctness-preserving fix benefiting any GENESIS/PGENESIS user, independent of accelerator use. We also fix three independent, previously unnoticed Hines-solver defects that silently suppressed `inject`-driven voltage transients in any multi-neuron `hsolve` configuration.

Keywords: GENESIS, PGENESIS, OpenCL, CUDA, GPU acceleration, compartmental neural simulation, Hines solver

Required Metadata

Current code version

Main text

1. Motivation and significance

Compartmental neural simulators remain essential for biophysically detailed models where channel kinetics and dendritic geometry cannot be abstracted away. GENESIS [1] is one of the longest-maintained simulators in this class, and PGENESIS extends it to MPI-distributed execution; both are still used in production modeling workflows, scripted via GENESIS’s SLI language, independent of newer simulator ecosystems. Modern workstations increasingly ship capable integrated GPUs, but GENESIS has no accelerator backend: every channel-kinetics update runs on the CPU regardless of available hardware, even though channel updates (per-compartment gating-variable integration) are embarrassingly parallel and GPU-friendly. Existing GENESIS/PGENESIS users have no path to accelerator support without abandoning their models and SLI scripts.

Existing accelerated simulators, and what they ask of a user.

Compartmental simulation on GPUs is not new, and the alternatives are mature. NEURON [11] is the most widely used simulator in this class; CoreNEURON [8] is its optimized compute engine, which strips the interpreter and runs the same models on GPUs through OpenACC, reaching large speedups on multi-rank and multi-GPU systems. Arbor [7] was written from scratch for many-core and GPU hardware,

Nr.	Code metadata description	Please fill in this column
C1	Current code version	v2.5 (2026-07-25; OpenCL + CUDA-validated, multi-compartment GPU Hines solve)
C2	Permanent GitHub link to code/repository used for this code version	https://github.com/WarsawIQ/genesis-2.5 (archived release: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21658389)
C3	Legal Code License	GNU General Public License v2 or later (program); GNU Lesser General Public License v2.1 or later (library portions) – see LICENSE
C4	Code versioning system used	git
C5	Software code languages, tools, and services used	C, OpenCL C, CUDA C++ (accelerator backends), MPI (PGENESIS), Python (benchmark analysis/plotting)
C6	Compilation requirements, operating environments & dependencies	Linux x86_64, GCC, GNU make, an OpenCL 1.2+ runtime (tested: ROCm 6.3.1 and Mesa rusticl) or a CUDA 12.x toolkit (tested: CUDA 12.8, sm_80 NVIDIA A100 and sm_86 NVIDIA A40 on the UMCS cluster) for the GPU backends, an MPI implementation for PGENESIS (MPICH/HYDRA or Open MPI tested on the UMCS cluster)
C7	If available Link to developer documentation/manual	README.md and paper/docs/REPLICATION.md in the repository
C8	Support email for questions	karol@chlasta.pl

Table 1: Code metadata (mandatory)

with a performance-portable back end and its own model description. For network models of point neurons rather than detailed morphologies, NEST [12] targets large-scale distributed simulation, and Brian 2 [13]

generates code from equations, with GPU execution available through GeNN [14].

Each of these is a strong choice for a new model. None is a path for an existing GENESIS model. CoreNEURON accelerates NEURON’s models, not GENESIS’s; Arbor and Brian 2 require the model to be re-expressed in their own descriptions; and a GENESIS user’s investment is typically in SLI scripts, `.p` cell files and channel prototypes accumulated over years. Porting is not a mechanical translation — as this work found, two implementations of the same published benchmark differ enough in channel kinetics and connectivity construction that establishing their equivalence is itself experimental work (Section 3). The gap GENESIS 2.5 addresses is therefore not “fastest simulator” but “acceleration without migration”: the same models and scripts, unchanged, on the hardware the user already has.

Contributions. This work contributes:

- 1.1 An opt-in OpenCL backend and a CUDA backend for the `hsolve` channel-update path, behind one entry point, leaving every existing CPU, MPI, model and SLI-script workflow unchanged.
- 1.2 `hines_tree_eliminate`, a GPU tridiagonal (Hines [10]) elimination kernel that extends acceleration from isopotential cells to axially-coupled multi-compartment dendritic trees, running the identical elimination the CPU solver does.
- 1.3 Four defects fixed in the accelerator that produced silently wrong results, and three in the Hines solver itself that suppressed `inject`-driven voltage transients in any multi-neuron `hsolve` — the latter independent of GPU use and therefore affecting existing GENESIS users.
- 1.4 A latent $O(n^2)$ model-construction bottleneck, unrelated to accelerator support, reduced to linear; populations that previously did not finish building now do so in under a minute.
- 1.5 A head-to-head evaluation against NEURON and CoreNEURON on a published network model, with the equivalence of the two implementations established rather than assumed, and a benchmarking protocol in which both arms are timed identically throughout.

GENESIS 2.5 closes this gap: GENESIS 2.4/PGENESIS 2.4 plus an OpenCL backend for the `hsolve` channel-update path, and a CUDA backend on the same interface (a faithful fp32 port, validated on UMCS cluster NVIDIA A100/A40 nodes; Section 3). No existing CPU, MPI, model, or SLI-script workflow needs to change. While validating this backend we additionally found and fixed three independent solver defects in `hines_solve.c/hines_init.c` affecting any multi-neuron `hsolve`

configuration: current injection (`inject`) silently failed to produce a voltage response prior to the fix, which would have invalidated any dynamics-comparing benchmark and may have affected unrelated multi-neuron `hsolve` models elsewhere.

Why a GPU helps here at all is specific to the workload. In a Hodgkin–Huxley model the per-compartment gating-variable integration is the dominant cost, and it is embarrassingly parallel: each compartment’s channel state advances from its own voltage and its own table lookups, with no coupling to any other compartment within the step. The state involved is small and the arithmetic intensity low, so the work maps onto thousands of lightweight threads without the memory pressure that limits many scientific kernels. This is why the channel-update path, rather than the tridiagonal solve, is the natural first target.

We provide both OpenCL and CUDA rather than choosing one because they buy different things. OpenCL is vendor-neutral and runs on the integrated GPUs now shipped with ordinary workstations, including devices without double-precision support — which is why the kernel is written in fp32 throughout. CUDA targets the NVIDIA datacenter and desktop cards where most cluster time is available and where the toolchain and profiling tools are standard. Both sit behind one entry point, so a model and its SLI script are unchanged between them and the choice is a build flag.

We name this release “2.5” rather than “3.0” deliberately: “GENESIS 3” [2] produced independent successor lines (Neurospaces/Hecker [3], MOOSE) evolving into the CBI federation [4, 5, 6], not a single artifact comparable to GENESIS 2.4. GENESIS 2.5 is not a re-architecture and targets existing GENESIS 2.4 deployments that should not need to migrate models or scripts to gain accelerator support.

2. Software description

2.1 Software architecture

GENESIS 2.5 keeps the existing GENESIS/PGENESIS architecture (SLI interpreter, `hsolve` fast compartmental solver, PGENESIS MPI partitioning) unmodified and adds one new component: an OpenCL backend invoked from `hsolve` when an attached `hsolve` element uses `chanmode=4` (or 5) with real ion-channel state. Two dispatch modes are implemented in `ocl_hsolve.c` against `genesis/src/hines/opencl/ocl_channel.cl`:

- *Per-step dispatch* (`ocl_chip_update`): one `clEnqueueNDRangeKernel` call per simulation step, with channel state uploaded and downloaded every step.

- *Multiloop dispatch* (`chip_channel_multiloop`, via `GENESIS_OCL_MULTILOOP=<K>`): a single kernel dispatch runs all K steps in an inner GPU-side loop, amortizing the per-step PCIe transfer cost that otherwise dominates wall time (Section 3).

Device attribution and dispatch are confirmed at run time: the command queue uses `CL_QUEUE_PROFILING_ENABLE`, and every accelerator run emits a non-empty `OCL PROFILING SUMMARY`; this guards against an `hsolve` with no attached channels never reaching the kernel, and against a kernel that fails to build silently falling back to CPU. The channel kernel is built in `float` (fp32), so it runs on runtimes exposing no fp64 support (Mesa rusticl on the AMD Radeon 890M used here); the rest of `hsolve` remains `double`, with conversion only at the buffer boundary.

Both dispatch modes update each compartment independently, exact only for single-compartment (isopotential) neurons: a real dendritic tree’s compartments are coupled through axial resistance, solved on the CPU by `hsolve` as a compiled bytecode program performing a bottom-up/top-down Gaussian elimination over the tree’s tridiagonal system once per step. We add a third kernel, `hines_tree_eliminate` (`ocl_channel.cl`; CUDA port in `cuda/cuda_channel.cuh`), executing this identical bytecode on the GPU, one thread per disconnected tree (neuron), operating on the same flat opcode/coefficient arrays the CPU solver already builds at `SETUP` time. Because independent trees never reference each other’s rows (the combined program is block-diagonal), threads need no synchronization. The channel and elimination kernels dispatch back to back on the same queue/stream, so the K -step batch still uploads and downloads state once. `ocl_hsolve.c/cuda_hsolve.c` select this path whenever the `hsolve` contains a multi-compartment tree, leaving the original kernel for single-compartment networks.

2.2 Software functionalities

- Unmodified serial (`genesis`), headless (`nxgenesis`), and MPI (`PGENESIS`) execution paths.
- OpenCL channel-update kernel for Hodgkin–Huxley-style `tabchannel` gating ($\text{Na } X^3Y^1$, $\text{K } X^4$), dispatched per-step or batched via multiloop.
- A CUDA backend on the same call site (`genesis/src/hines/cuda/`): a line-for-line fp32 port of the OpenCL kernels behind an identical entry point, so the same models and harness

drive either backend. Validated on UMCS A100/A40 nodes (Section 3).

- Device-side dispatch confirmation (`OCL/CUDA PROFILING SUMMARY`) distinguishing a genuine GPU run from CPU fallback.
- A driven-spiking benchmark (`hh_spiking_benchmark.g`): N Hodgkin–Huxley neurons under one `hsolve`, driven suprathreshold to fire action-potential trains, exercising the repaired `inject` path.
- Three corrected Hines-solver defects (forward-elimination fast-path guard, backward-elimination root handling, `SET_DIAG/SKIP_DIAG` row selection) giving correct, independent per-neuron voltage dynamics under current injection, independent of GPU support.
- A GPU tridiagonal (Hines) elimination kernel, `hines_tree_eliminate` (OpenCL and CUDA), extending acceleration to real, axially-coupled multi-compartment dendritic trees (Section 3).
- Five corrected $O(n^2)$ model-construction defects in core GENESIS element-creation, path-resolution, and `hsolve` `SETUP` code, restoring linear-time construction independent of GPU support (Section 3).

The tridiagonal (Hines) elimination kernel is what decides whether any of this reaches realistic morphologies. Accelerating channel updates alone leaves the axial coupling between compartments on the CPU, so a multi-compartment model gains little: the solve becomes the bottleneck as soon as the channel work is removed from it. `hines_tree_eliminate` moves that solve onto the device as well, running the identical elimination the CPU performs, one thread per neuron. The consequence is a change in kind rather than degree — acceleration stops being limited to isopotential point-neuron networks and applies to populations of real dendritic trees, which is the regime Section 3 measures.

3. Illustrative examples

Reproducing the CPU baseline. `nxgenesis` on the bundled `Ca18.g` and `Ca17difshell.g` models gives stable, low-variance timings (CV $\approx 1\%$, 30 replicates), confirming ordinary GENESIS workflows are unaffected by this release.

Reproducing the GPU multiloop result. `genesis/Scripts/benchmark/hh_spiking_benchmark.g` builds N driven, spiking Hodgkin–Huxley neurons under one `hsolve` (`chanmode=4`); `GENESIS_OCL_MULTILoop=K` dispatches all K steps in one GPU call. Both arms (`nxgenesis_nocl`

fp64 CPU; `nxgenesis` fp32 multiloop, AMD Radeon 890M) are timed identically at $K = 50\,000$ and $K = 0$, isolating the *simulation phase* from construction; 30+ reps, 95% CIs in `experiments/data/campaign_wallclock_summary.csv`.

Table 2 and Fig. 1 report the result after the scheduler and solver fixes. Step-phase speedup peaks near $N = 5000$ at $\sim 18\times$ sustained and $\sim 13.5\times$ cold-start ($\sim 1.5 \times 10^9$ neuron-steps/s); the gap reflects the idle, downclocked GPU during construction. Beyond $N \approx 10\,000$ the integrated GPU no longer sustains its fast clock state and speedup falls toward $\sim 3\times$. End-to-end speedup peaks at $\sim 4\times$ and approaches the step-phase figure as simulations lengthen (Fig. 5).

N	CPU step (s)	GPU step (s)	Step-phase sustained	Step-phase single-run	Throughput (M nsteps/s)
500	0.302	0.112	$2.7\times$	$2.0\times$	223
1 000	0.587	0.112	$5.2\times$	$3.7\times$	446
2 000	1.166	0.117	$10.0\times$	$6.5\times$	855
5 000	2.965	0.164	$18.1\times$	$13.5\times$	1524
10 000	5.799	0.406	$14.3\times$	$6.8\times$	1232
20 000	11.918	3.283	$3.6\times$	$3.1\times$	305
50 000	31.179	9.880	$3.2\times$	$3.2\times$	253

Table 2: GPU multiloop (fp32) vs. CPU (fp64) baseline, AMD Radeon 890M, driven spiking neurons, $K = 50\,000$ steps. “Sustained” is the warm steady-state dispatch; “single-run” is a cold-start run, $\sim 1.3\text{--}2\times$ slower. End-to-end (incl. construction) speedup is $1.2\text{--}4.2\times$. Raw data: `experiments/data/campaign_warm_dispatch.csv`, `experiments/data/campaign_wallclock_summary.csv`, `experiments/data/campaign_reproducibility.csv`.

Numerical fidelity of the fp32 accelerator. `genesis/Scripts/benchmark/hh1952_ap_verify.g` compares the classic 1952 squid AP across CPU fp64, GPU per-step, and GPU multiloop paths: fp32 agrees with fp64 to $\sim 2 \times 10^{-7}$ V over a single AP, all N neurons identical to $< 10^{-6}$ V (Fig. 2). Over long spiking runs, fp32/fp64 traces drift in spike *phase* but preserve waveform and firing rate, why timing uses driven neurons while correctness uses a single-AP window.

CUDA backend on NVIDIA hardware. The CUDA backend builds from the same source (`make USE_CUDA=1`) against the identical harness, and reproduces the fp64 CPU action potential to 7×10^{-8} V, confirming parity with both the CPU and OpenCL paths. Table 3 reports a 10-replicate sweep on the two UMCS cluster GPUs.

These are *end-to-end* speedups: both arms are timed by wall clock around the whole process, so construction, host–device transfers and

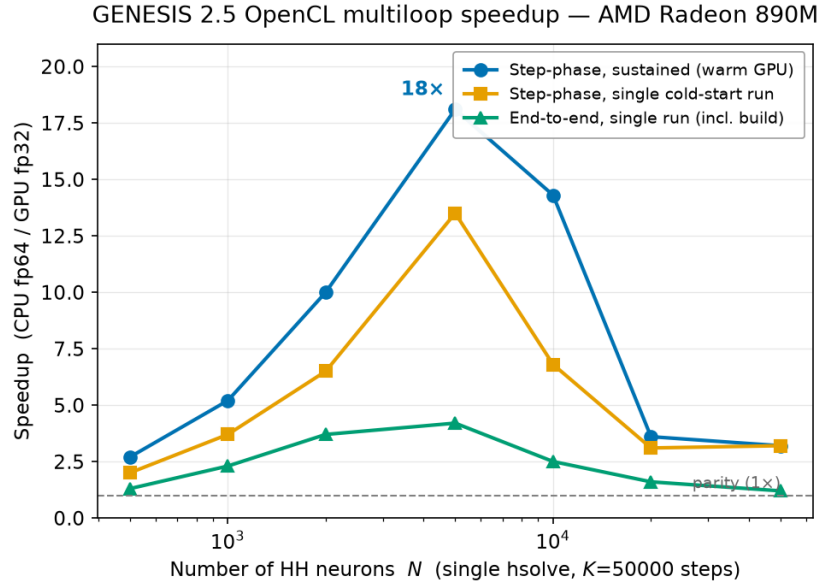


Figure 1: Measured wall-clock speedup, GPU multiloop (fp32) vs. CPU (fp64), sustained and cold-start step-phase, and end-to-end (single run). Both step-phase series peak near $N = 5000$ and fall beyond $N \approx 10000$ as the integrated GPU stops sustaining its fast clocks.

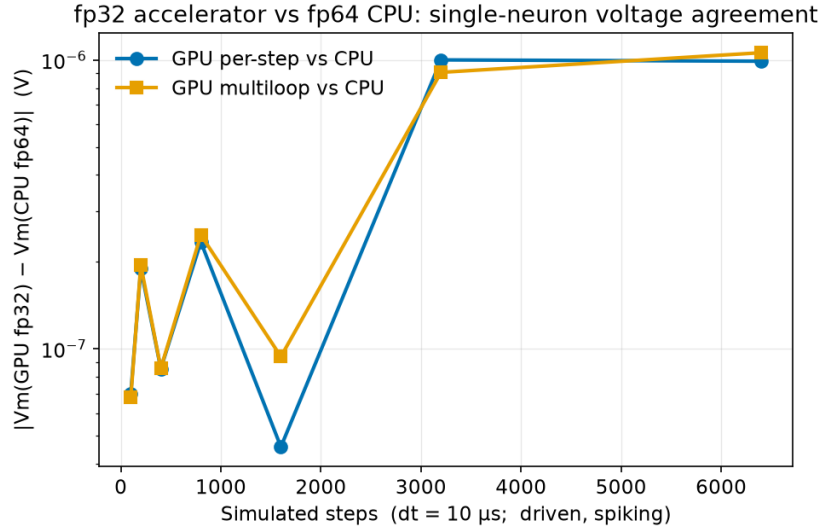


Figure 2: fp32 accelerator vs. fp64 CPU: absolute membrane-voltage difference for a single neuron as a function of simulated steps, for both the per-step and multiloop GPU paths.

all per-step host work are inside the measurement. This matters more than it may appear. An earlier version of this campaign took the

CPU number from GENESIS’s own `{cpu}` step-loop timer and the GPU number from the device-side `CUDA MULTILoop` kernel report — two different quantities, with everything outside the kernel excluded from the GPU side. That comparison gave $212.7\times$ on the A40 at $N = 50\,000$ where the end-to-end figure is $21.0\times$, a factor of ten. It also manufactured an apparent ordering between the cards: under the mixed definition the A40 appeared to beat the A100 at every N , which invited a hardware explanation. Measured consistently the two are indistinguishable ($21.0 \pm 0.3\times$ vs. $21.9 \pm 0.3\times$), and the earlier gap was an artefact of what was being timed.

The speedup grows with network size rather than peaking as the integrated GPU does (Table 2), and at $N = 500$ the accelerator barely pays for itself: at that size the fixed costs of construction and transfer dominate a run that the CPU finishes in under a second.

N	NVIDIA A40		NVIDIA A100	
	CPU (s)	end-to-end	CPU (s)	end-to-end
500	0.76	$1.5 \pm 0.1\times$	0.78	$1.8 \pm 0.3\times$
5 000	5.70	$8.7 \pm 0.3\times$	5.86	$9.7 \pm 0.4\times$
50 000	57.06	$21.0 \pm 0.3\times$	58.47	$21.9 \pm 0.3\times$

Table 3: CUDA backend (fp32) vs. CPU (fp64), single-compartment multiloop kernel (`hh_spiking_benchmark.g`, $K = 50\,000$ steps), UMCS cluster. Mean of 10 replicates; the quoted uncertainty propagates the standard deviations of both arms. **Both arms are timed identically**, by wall clock around the whole process, so the ratio is end-to-end and includes construction, transfers and per-step host work — see `cluster_bringup/53_singlecomp_walltime.sh`. The two cards are indistinguishable at every size. Raw data: `cluster_bringup/logs/singlecomp_walltime_inf02_20260815_132840.csv` (A40), `.._inf03_20260815_135147.csv` (A100).

Multi-compartment GPU acceleration. The multiloop kernel above is exact only for single-compartment (isopotential) neurons: for a real dendritic tree it silently drops all axial coupling. `hines_tree_eliminate` (Section 2.1) performs this elimination on-device, dispatched whenever the `hsolve` contains a multi-compartment tree.

Correctness. `hh_multicompartment_benchmark.g` (linear-chain) and `hh_branching_multicompartment_benchmark.g` (branching, exercising sibling-array opcodes) compare GPU (chanmode 4) against CPU (chanmode 1, fp64) across $N_{\text{COMP}} = 1\text{--}32$, up to 4 branches, and up to $N = 10\,000$ neurons: agreement is $\sim 10^{-7}$ V, matching single-compartment fidelity. One narrow topology is known not to be handled: a single-compartment branch directly off a branch point — a row that is simultaneously a leaf and has siblings — and only in the first tree built,

which is the one covered by the kernel’s bootstrap special case. Trees beyond the first pass with the identical shape, which isolates the fault to that bootstrap’s seed-row assumption rather than to the elimination itself. The shape does not arise in GENESIS dendrite models, where a branch that extends no further is simply an odd way of modelling the soma. It had been documented as a limitation but not enforced, so a model containing it was accelerated and returned wrong voltages silently; both backends now detect the shape when the accelerator initialises for an `hsolve`, decline that `hsolve` and compute it on the CPU with a message, on the same pattern used for unsupported opcodes.

Speed. Table 4 and Fig. 3 report speedup (mean $\pm$ std, 10 replicates) on the two UMCS cards, sweeping $N = 100$ –50 000 at `NCOMP` = 16, a range unreachable before the model-construction fix (Impact): $N = 50\,000$ took 23.8 ± 0.3 s to build there, versus not finishing before. Branching topology gives statistically indistinguishable speedups and is omitted from the figure. Dispatch uses $K = 200$ steps ($K = 100$ for $N \geq 5000$), smaller than the single-compartment sweeps’ $K = 50\,000$.

We report two figures per card, because they answer different questions. The *step-phase* speedup times the simulation loop alone and measures what the kernel can do: both cards are slower than CPU at $N \leq 500$, pull ahead past $N \approx 500$ –1000, and reach $37.3 \pm 0.1\times$ (A40) and $80.8 \pm 1.0\times$ (A100) at $N = 50\,000$, neither plateaued. The *end-to-end* speedup wall-clocks the whole process and is what a user experiences: it is far lower, $3.62 \pm 0.05\times$ (A40) and $3.90 \pm 0.07\times$ (A100) at $N = 50\,000$. The gap is not a kernel deficiency but Amdahl’s law applied to a short run — at $K = 200$ steps the unaccelerated construction phase dominates, and Fig. 5 shows the end-to-end figure climbing toward the step-phase ceiling as K grows. Quoting only the step-phase number would overstate what the accelerator delivers in practice.

The two cards are close on the end-to-end measure and the A100’s lead is modest, even though it leads the A40 by more than $2\times$ on the step phase — the opposite ordering from the single-compartment kernel (Table 3). This is consistent with an fp32 kernel that uses no tensor cores: at $N = 50\,000$ the GPU phases take 7.83 s (A40) and 8.06 s (A100), so once construction is included the two cards are nearly indistinguishable. Raw data: `cluster_bringup/logs/weekend_campaign_inf02_A40_20260816_clean.csv`, `..._inf03_A100_20260816_clean.csv` (step-phase), and `cluster_bringup/logs/multicomp_walltime_createmap*_clean.csv` (end-to-end).

Parallelization granularity. `hines_tree_eliminate` assigns one GPU thread per tree, so speedup comes from spreading many neurons across

threads, not from parallelizing elimination *within* a tree. For a single detailed morphology alone ($N = 1$), only one thread is active: measured directly (AMD Radeon 890M), the kernel is $\sim 20\text{--}21\times$ *slower* than the CPU at `NCOMP` = 2000 and 8000, stable with tree size as expected for a single-thread bottleneck. The kernel therefore accelerates population-scale simulation (Table 4), not the single-detailed-cell regime.

N	total comps	step-phase		end-to-end	
		A40	A100	A40	A100
100	1 600	0.2 ± 0.02	0.3 ± 0.02	0.43 ± 0.05	0.61 ± 0.02
500	8 000	1.1 ± 0.03	1.7 ± 0.11	0.77 ± 0.02	1.04 ± 0.03
1 000	16 000	2.0 ± 0.08	3.1 ± 0.07	1.10 ± 0.08	1.46 ± 0.04
2 000	32 000	4.5 ± 0.39	6.4 ± 0.18	1.37 ± 0.06	1.57 ± 0.05
3 000	48 000	6.7 ± 0.03	12.0 ± 0.37	1.87 ± 0.07	1.89 ± 0.04
5 000	80 000	6.9 ± 0.04	14.5 ± 0.47	2.60 ± 0.06	2.66 ± 0.03
7 000	112 000	9.8 ± 0.05	22.0 ± 0.43	2.92 ± 0.05	3.08 ± 0.03
10 000	160 000	13.7 ± 0.06	30.6 ± 0.68	3.01 ± 0.04	3.23 ± 0.04
15 000	240 000	20.3 ± 0.12	42.3 ± 0.77	3.27 ± 0.05	3.52 ± 0.03
20 000	320 000	25.3 ± 0.12	51.6 ± 1.16	3.39 ± 0.04	3.71 ± 0.04
30 000	480 000	31.9 ± 0.13	66.1 ± 1.12	3.53 ± 0.05	3.87 ± 0.05
40 000	640 000	35.2 ± 0.13	75.5 ± 0.96	3.56 ± 0.04	3.90 ± 0.04
50 000	800 000	37.3 ± 0.07	80.8 ± 1.01	3.62 ± 0.05	3.90 ± 0.07

Table 4: Multi-compartment GPU tree-elimination (fp32) vs. CPU (fp64), UMCS A40/A100, `NCOMP` = 16, linear-chain, batched multiloop ($K = 200$, $K = 100$ for $N \geq 5000$); mean $\pm$ std over 10 replicates. *Step-phase* times the simulation loop alone and measures kernel capability; *end-to-end* wall-clocks the whole process, including model construction, and is what a user experiences. The two arms of the end-to-end measurement are timed identically – see `cluster_bringup/54_multicomp_walltime.sh`. The end-to-end runs build the population with a single `createmap` from a prototype, as network models do, rather than the explicit SLI loop of the original benchmark; the step-phase figures are unaffected by that choice, since they exclude construction. “–” = not measured. Raw data: `cluster_bringup/logs/weekend_campaign_inf02_A40_20260816_clean.csv` and `..._inf03_A100_20260816_clean.csv` (step-phase), `cluster_bringup/logs/multicomp_walltime_createmap_inf02_A40_clean.csv` and `..._inf03_A100_clean.csv` (end-to-end).

Population-scale model construction was $O(n^2)$; now $O(n)$. Pushing the multi-compartment benchmark toward the $\sim 31\,000$ -neuron Blue Brain Project scale [9] exposed a defect independent of GPU support: building $N = 31\,000$ 17-compartment neurons (527 000 compartments) did not finish within 900s, though Table 4 only required 160 000. Profiling found a fitted exponent of 2.31 ($O(n^2)$), traced to five pre-existing linear-scan-per-element patterns in core GENE-

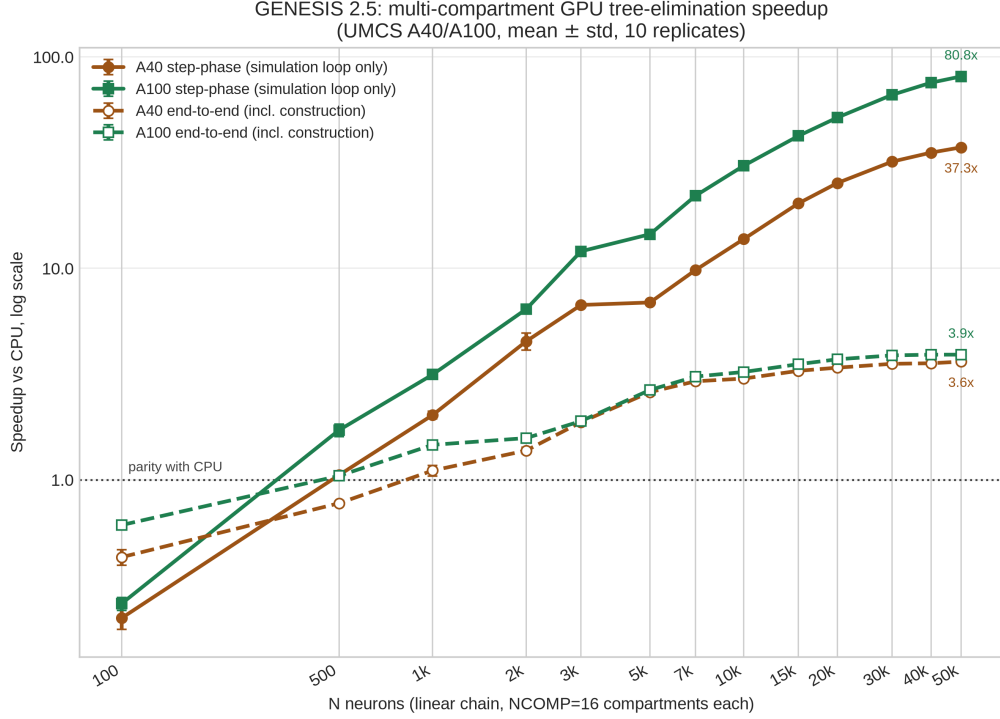


Figure 3: Multi-compartment GPU tree-elimination speedup vs. CPU (mean $\pm$ std, 10 replicates; log-log), UMCS A40/A100, sweeping N at $\text{NCOMP} = 16$ (linear-chain). Colour identifies the card, line style the metric: solid = step-phase (simulation loop only), dashed = end-to-end (whole process, including model construction). Both cards start below CPU parity and cross it near $N \approx 500$ – 1000 . The step-phase curves keep climbing to $80.8\times$ (A100) and $37.3\times$ (A40) without plateauing, but the end-to-end curves flatten near $3.9\times$ and $3.6\times$: at $K = 200$ steps the unaccelerated construction phase bounds the achievable speedup, and only the step-phase curves measure the kernel itself. The two cards nearly coincide end-to-end despite the A100’s large step-phase lead, as expected for an fp32 kernel using no tensor cores.

SIS code (element creation, path resolution, `hsolve SETUP`), none GPU-specific: each rescanned siblings, paths, or compartments in $O(n)$ where hashing or amortized growth would do. We fixed all five with hash-based lookups, load-factor rehashing, and geometric growth. Table 5 and Fig. 4 show a fitted exponent of 0.99 after, effectively linear, extended to $N = 100\,000$ (1.7 million compartments): the 527 000-compartment population now builds in 14.6 ± 0.2 s, down from not finishing, and the 1.7-million-compartment population in 51.5 ± 0.6 s. Changes were verified to produce byte-identical output on every validation script, confirming a pure performance fix; full diagnosis in `genesis/src/hines/GPU_HINES_SOLVE_DESIGN.md`.

N	total comps	before (s)	after: mean $\pm$ std (s)	CV
1 000	17 000	0.82	0.57 ± 0.08	13.2%
2 000	34 000	2.03	0.93 ± 0.003	0.3%
4 000	68 000	8.24	1.83 ± 0.04	1.9%
8 000	136 000	105.45	4.08 ± 0.03	0.7%
16 000	272 000	did not finish (60 s+)	7.54 ± 0.02	0.2%
31 000	527 000	did not finish (900 s+)	14.57 ± 0.18	1.2%
50 000	850 000	–	23.80 ± 0.32	1.3%
70 000	1 190 000	–	34.25 ± 0.44	1.3%
100 000	1 700 000	–	51.48 ± 0.61	1.2%

Table 5: Model-construction wall time (construction + `hsolve SETUP` + one step), `hh_branching_multicompartment_benchmark.g`, local machine, before vs. after the five fixes. “After”: mean $\pm$ std, 3 replicates; “before”: single replicate, not re-measured beyond $N = 8000$ (“–” = never attempted). Fitted exponent: 2.31 before, 0.99 after. Raw data: `experiments/data/construction_scaling_before_after.csv`.

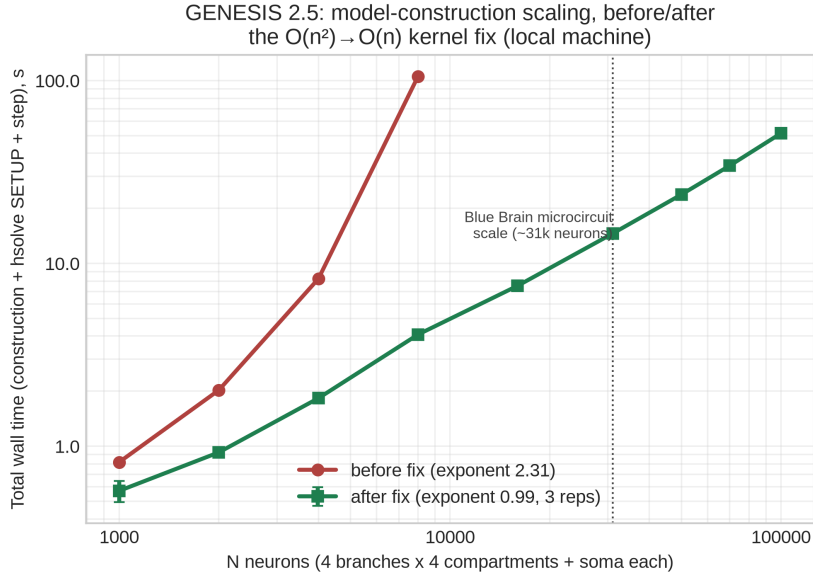


Figure 4: Model-construction wall time vs. N , log-log, before (single replicate) and after (mean $\pm$ std, 3 replicates) the five $O(n^2)$ fixes, extended to $N = 100\,000$. The “before” series stops at $N = 8000$: larger N did not finish within the tested budget.

Speedup grows with simulation length. Model construction is a fixed one-time cost, so end-to-end speedup depends on run length. Sweeping K at fixed $N = 5000$ (Fig. 5) shows end-to-end speedup rising toward the step-phase ceiling: the accelerator pays off most for the long runs typical of real modeling studies (`experiments/data/campaign_`

ksweep.csv).

The multi-compartment figures are a floor set by the benchmark, not a ceiling set by the kernel. The sweeps above use $K = 200$ ($K = 100$ for $N \geq 5000$), which at $dt = 50 \mu\text{s}$ is 5–10 ms of simulated activity — short enough that fixed costs dominate both arms. Repeating the measurement at $N = 10\,000$ over a range of K (Table 6) separates them: end-to-end speedup rises from $4.3\times$ at $K = 200$ to $57.0 \pm 0.9\times$ at $K = 5000$, and step-phase from $13.7\times$ to $116.2\times$. Both grow because the one-time costs they contain — model construction for the end-to-end figure, buffer setup and the single batched dispatch for the step-phase figure — are amortized over more steps.

Fitting fixed and marginal costs to the sweep separates them directly: construction is $\approx 1.3\text{ s}$ on both arms, while the marginal cost of one step is $2.31 \times 10^{-2}\text{ s}$ on the CPU against $1.42 \times 10^{-4}\text{ s}$ on the GPU, a ratio of $163\times$. The device-side profile agrees independently, reporting $140.4 \mu\text{s}$ per step for the two tree kernels. The GPU arm reproduces the CPU voltages to $\sim 10^{-7}\text{ V}$ at $K = 5000$, the same fidelity as the short runs, so this is amortization rather than skipped work.

We report the short- K figures in Table 4 because they are what the standing benchmark measures, but they understate what the kernel delivers in any realistic study: a 250 ms simulation of this population already reaches $57\times$ end-to-end.

K steps	CPU (s)	GPU (s)	End-to-end
200	5.86	1.37	4.28 ± 0.12
500	13.00	1.42	9.18 ± 0.25
1 000	24.87	1.49	16.73 ± 0.36
2 000	48.03	1.63	29.48 ± 0.91
5 000	116.75	2.05	57.01 ± 0.88

Table 6: End-to-end wall clock against simulation length, $N = 10\,000$ neurons $\times$ 16 compartments (160 000 compartments), UMCS A40, mean $\pm$ std over 5 replicates, both arms timed identically. The fixed cost each arm carries — $\approx 1.3\text{ s}$ of model construction — is unchanged across the sweep, so the speedup rises as K grows: at $K = 200$ construction is most of the GPU run, at $K = 5000$ it is under a tenth of it. Raw data: `cluster_bringup/logs/multicomp_ksweep_inf02_A40_20260816.csv`, produced by `cluster_bringup/55_multicomp_ksweep.sh`.

Reproducing the PGENESIS scaling result. The existing MPI path is unaffected; a strong-scaling sweep ($N = 2400$ HH neurons, $P = 1$ –24 ranks, 12-core/24-thread host) gives near-ideal scaling at $P = 2$ ($E_P = 0.95$), an efficiency knee near $P \approx 5$, and a recommended $P = 4$ –8 (3.1 – $4.0\times$, 50–78% efficiency) for this problem size.

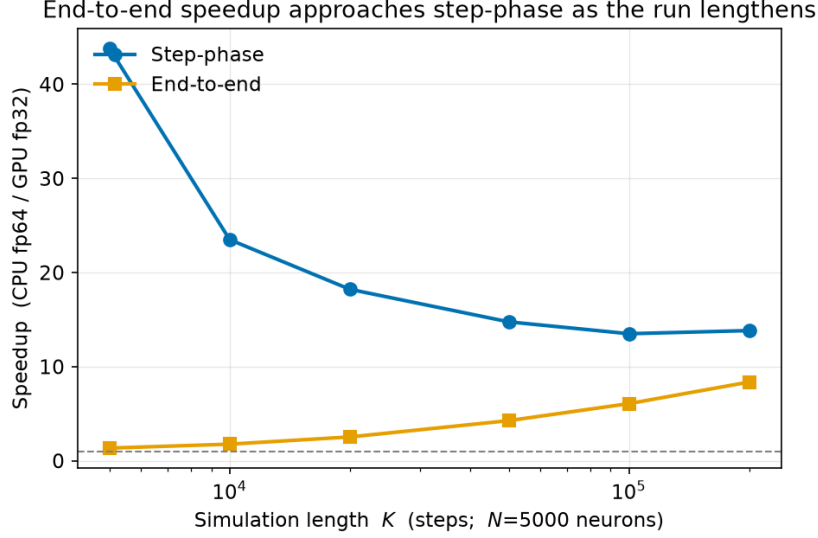


Figure 5: Speedup vs. simulation length K at fixed $N = 5000$. As the run lengthens, the one-time model-construction cost amortizes and the end-to-end speedup approaches the step-phase (simulation-only) speedup.

Head-to-head against NEURON and CoreNEURON. The speedups above are internal (GPU vs. CPU within GENESIS) and say nothing about how GENESIS compares with other simulators. We therefore ran the Vogels–Abbott COBAHH network [15, 16] in GENESIS (`Scripts/VAnet2`) and in the reference NEURON implementation (ModelDB 83319, `NEURON/cobahh`) on the same cluster node, all arms single-threaded on CPU (Table 7). GENESIS 2.5 completes the 5.0s simulation in 46.9 ± 2.1 s, $1.63 \pm 0.07\times$ faster than CoreNEURON and $2.04 \pm 0.09\times$ faster than NEURON 9.0.2. In throughput terms the run advances 4×10^8 neuron-steps, so GENESIS sustains 8.5×10^6 neuron-steps/s against 5.2×10^6 for CoreNEURON and 4.2×10^6 for NEURON.

This ordering is worth stating plainly, because it is not the one a reader would assume. CoreNEURON exists specifically to make NEURON models run faster: it discards the interpreter, rebuilds the data layout for cache efficiency and vectorisation, and is the engine used for NEURON’s largest published simulations. GENESIS 2.5, by contrast, is a 2.4-era codebase with an accelerator added to one path, and the arm measured here does not use that accelerator at all — it is the plain CPU solver. That it still finishes the same network in two thirds of CoreNEURON’s time indicates that GENESIS’s tabulated-channel CPU solver is competitive with a purpose-built optimised engine, which

is not a claim the previous version of this manuscript was in a position to make.

CoreNEURON is in turn $1.25\times$ faster than NEURON 9.0.2, the expected ordering, which indicates the CoreNEURON arm is configured correctly rather than accidentally handicapped.

Because these are independent implementations of one benchmark, equivalence was established rather than assumed. Both networks have 4000 single-compartment cells (3200 excitatory, 800 inhibitory) and 80 synapses per cell; both are driven externally for the first 50 ms only and then run on recurrent activity alone; both use $dt = 0.05$ ms for 5.0 s. Critically, both settle into the same dynamical regime — 26.8 Hz mean firing rate in GENESIS (536 600 spikes) against 27.9 Hz in NEURON (558 824), a 4% difference — so neither is doing materially less synaptic work than the other. Measuring the GENESIS rate required instrumenting every spikegen: the benchmark records membrane potential from three cells, two of which lie on the edge and corner of the grid where distance-dependent connectivity leaves them underconnected, and they fire at 7.6 and 0.6 Hz against 15.8 Hz centrally.

The stock NEURON benchmark cannot run under CoreNEURON at all: its sodium and potassium channels are ChannelBuilder objects reconstructed inside the interpreter, and CoreNEURON, having no interpreter, aborts in `nrn_setup` with "nahh mechanism does not exist". We transcribed both channels into NMODL; the transcription is exact, reproducing the published COBAHH rate equations at $V_T = -63$ mV, and CoreNEURON then yields a spike train byte-identical to NEURON's with the same compiled channels. Harness, mechanisms and full method are in `cluster_bringup/coreneuron/`.

This comparison establishes a single-core baseline only. CoreNEURON targets GPU and multi-rank MPI execution, and exercises neither here; the GENESIS arm is likewise its CPU arm, since VAnet2 cannot yet use the accelerator efficiently (Section 2.1).

Full replication steps and raw data are in `paper/docs/REPLICATION.md` and the self-contained `experiments/` package.

4. Impact

GENESIS/PGENESIS users with channel-kinetics-heavy models now have a path to GPU acceleration (Section 3) without migrating models, SLI scripts, or MPI workflows. That is the principal barrier an architecturally different successor such as MOOSE would otherwise impose. The three Hines-solver defects fixed along the way (Section 2) are independent of GPU support and affect any multi-neuron `hsolve` configuration: before the fix, `inject`-driven voltage transients were silently

Simulator	Channels	Wall (s)	Spikes
GENESIS 2.5 (VAnet2)	tabulated	46.9 $\pm$ 2.1	536 600
CoreNEURON 9.0.2	compiled NMODL	76.5 $\pm$ 0.3	558 824
NEURON 9.0.2	compiled NMODL	95.8 $\pm$ 0.2	558 824
NEURON 9.0.2	ChannelBuilder	123.3	574 138
NEURON 8.0.2	ChannelBuilder	76.5	—

Table 7: Vogels–Abbott COBAHH network, 4000 single-compartment cells, 80 synapses per cell, $dt = 0.05$ ms, 5.0 s simulated, UMCS node inf03, all arms single-threaded CPU. Mean $\pm$ std over 3 replicates for the top three rows; the two ChannelBuilder rows are single runs, shown for reference only. GENESIS 2.5 is $1.63 \pm 0.07\times$ faster than CoreNEURON. The two simulators reach the same activity regime (26.8 vs. 27.9 Hz), so the wall times reflect comparable work. All NEURON and CoreNEURON replicates returned an identical spike count, confirming the runs are deterministic. NEURON 8.0.2 is included because its pip distribution ships the CoreNEURON Python interface but not the engine, so the CoreNEURON arm requires NEURON 9. Harness: `cluster_bringup/coreneuron/`.

suppressed for every neuron but the first, with no error raised. That defect predates this release and is now fixed for any multi-neuron `hsolve` user, whether or not they use an accelerator.

Bringing up the accelerator backends surfaced four confounds: a GUI-linked binary, a benchmark that never dispatches to the kernel, CPU-timer semantics that overstate GPU-blocked wait as compute, and an off-by-one `argc` guard. Each produced a false reading at some point, and the wall-clock protocol built to catch them should generalize to any future GENESIS accelerator backend. On the UMCS cluster this scaled to 10-replicate statistical rigor for both kernels (Tables 3, 4), the multi-generation GPU comparison the cluster access was meant to provide. The dominant early cost was a broken $O(N)$ scheduler loop leaving neurons $2 \dots N$ unabsorbed and re-scheduled every step; fixing it is what makes Section 3’s numbers possible. A further, structural limit remained: the multiloop kernel updates each compartment independently, so it only works for single-compartment networks. `hines_tree_eliminate` (Section 2.1, Section 3) closes that gap for population-scale simulation, parallelizing across neurons rather than within one tree.

The accelerator is deliberately scoped, and the scope is worth stating precisely rather than leaving to be discovered. Both kernels interpret the `hsolve` opcode program directly and implement the five opcodes a Hodgkin–Huxley `tabchannel` model driven by current injection produces. Compartments needing anything else — synaptic channels, a `spike` element, GHK, calcium concentration pools — are detected at

SETUP and computed on the CPU, the accelerator declining that `hsolve` and reporting why. Validating this on a published network model exposed a fourth latent defect: the detection existed but its result was never consulted, so such compartments were dispatched to a kernel that mis-parses their opcode stream, giving wrong voltages from the first step with no error raised. It affected none of the benchmarks reported here, since none uses those elements; it affects any real network model that does. The check is now enforced, and the boundary it enforces is the honest statement of what this release accelerates.

Pushing toward the Blue Brain Project’s scale [9] turned up a defect entirely separate from the GPU work: five pre-existing linear-scan patterns compounding into $O(n^2)$ model-construction time (Section 3). None is accelerator-specific, so fixing all five benefits any GENESIS/PGENESIS user building a large model: a second latent defect found only because this work pushed the codebase to a scale it had apparently never seen before.

5. Conclusions

GENESIS 2.5 adds opt-in OpenCL and CUDA acceleration to GENESIS 2.4/PGENESIS 2.4 for Hodgkin–Huxley `tabchannel` models, without changes to model files, SLI scripts, or MPI workflows (Section 3 reports speedup and fidelity for both integrated-GPU and cluster-class hardware). Beyond the single-compartment multiloop kernel, `hines_tree_eliminate` extends acceleration to axially-coupled multi-compartment trees at population scale; the single-detailed-cell regime is not helped by this design, which we measure and report rather than omit.

The release also carries four correctness fixes independent of accelerator use, benefiting any GENESIS/PGENESIS user. Three are latent Hines-solver defects that silently suppressed `inject`-driven voltage transients in any multi-neuron `hsolve`. The fourth is in the accelerator dispatch itself: compartments using opcodes the kernels do not implement were sent to the GPU anyway, producing silently wrong results; they are now detected and computed on the CPU. Separately, five pre-existing linear-scan patterns compounding into $O(n^2)$ model-construction time are fixed, restoring linear scaling and making population-scale models buildable at all.

Measured against other simulators on a published network model, GENESIS 2.5 is $1.63 \pm 0.07\times$ faster than CoreNEURON and $2.04 \pm 0.09\times$ faster than NEURON 9.0.2 for single-threaded CPU execution of the Vogels–Abbott COBAHH benchmark, with the equivalence of the two implementations established rather than assumed (Section 3).

Future work. Four directions follow directly from the limits measured

here, in what we judge to be descending order of value to users.

Scale. The kernel assigns one thread per tree, so it accelerates population-scale simulation and not the single detailed cell, where only one thread is active and the GPU is $\sim 20\times$ slower than the CPU. Intra-tree parallelism — cyclic reduction or a comparable parallel tridiagonal scheme — would extend acceleration to the detailed-morphology regime that much of the compartmental-modelling literature works in. This is the dimension along which the present design is furthest from complete.

Coverage. Synaptically coupled networks are currently declined rather than accelerated, because the kernels implement only the opcodes a `tabchannel` model driven by current injection produces. Extending coverage to synaptic channels, spike generators and concentration pools would bring the accelerator to the models most GENESIS users actually run. A structural obstacle sits behind this: GENESIS associates one spike generator with each `hsolve`, so a spiking network is built as one solver per cell, and per-solver dispatch overhead then dominates. Batching dispatch across `hsolve` elements is the corresponding fix, and it interacts with event ordering, since a spike raised inside a batch cannot reach another cell’s synapses before the batch ends.

Comparison. The head-to-head reported here is single-threaded CPU on one node. CoreNEURON is designed for GPU and multi-rank MPI execution, and Arbor for many-core hardware; a comparison across those configurations, and against Arbor on a network reimplemented with the same care taken here, would place GENESIS 2.5 more completely.

Precision. The kernels are fp32 throughout, which is what lets them run on integrated GPUs lacking double precision, and which costs $\sim 10^{-7}$ V against the fp64 CPU over the runs measured. Whether that divergence stays bounded over the much longer runs used in plasticity or development studies is not established here and should be characterised before such models rely on it.

Packaging into a container-based on-premise/cloud deployment pipeline [17] is in progress.

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Current executable software version

Not applicable; this release is distributed as source code only (see Current code version above).